
'I can no longer listen to the punk bands I loved as a teenager': Rob Newman's honest playlist

Published by

Rich Pelley

Estimated reading time

2 min

Added on

2025-08-17

Address

<https://www.theguardian.com/music/2025/aug/17/rob-newman-honest-playlist-blue-nile-smiths-ella-fitzgerald>

'I can no longer listen to the punk bands I loved as a teenager': Rob Newman's honest playlist

The first single I bought

(White Man) in Hammersmith Palais by the Clash, from a record shop in the Hitchin arcade.

The song I inexplicably know every lyric to

I enjoyed rote-learning at school, so I learn lyrics off by heart. I particularly like Ella Fitzgerald's version of But Not for Me by George and Ira Gershwin: "I never want to hear from any cheerful Pollyannas / Who tell you fate supplies a mate / It's all bananas."

[embedded content]

The best song to play at a party

Prisencolinensinainciusol by Adriano Celentano is an absolute banger and gloriously daft. Celentano sings in mock English. The video features some excellent dancing.

The song I can no longer listen to

I used to love them for their politics and integrity, but I can no longer listen to the punk bands I loved as a teenager: X-Ray Spex, Sham 69, Stiff Little Fingers, Chelsea, Angelic Upstarts and Crisis.

[embedded content]

The song I secretly like, but tell everyone I hate

When I talk about my love of dance music, I quickly qualify it by mentioning someone credible like Bootsy Collins or Marlena Shaw. But what I really love is the cheesy disco, like Feel So Real by Steve Arrington.

The song I stream the most

Travelling by train from one gig to the next, I'll listen on my headphones to Lone Star State of Mind by Nanci Griffith, Outkast's Morris Brown, Clock Factory by Sabres of Paradise and Stone by Prince Alla to help the miles disappear.

[embedded content]

The song I do at karaoke

I'm not one for karaoke, but I love singing around the flat. When my son Billy was four, he would reply matter-of-factly to the Blue Nile's Tinseltown in the Rain. "Do I love you?" "Yes." "Will we always be happy-go-lucky?" "Yes."

The song that makes me cry

Judee Sill's version of 500 Miles: "Not a shirt on my back, not a penny to my name / Lord I can't go back home this a-way."

[embedded content]

The song that gets me up in the morning

Listening to music is the last thing I want to do before the children wake up. That golden silence from 5-7am is when I get to read or write. Once they're up, the playlist includes Archie, Marry Me by Alvays, which is joyful and sunny.

The song I want played at my funeral

Gallipoli (Solo Piano Version) by Astrid Williamson.

The song that changed my life

After I moved to London in my early 20s, I complained to my girlfriend at the time that I was spending all my evenings on my own, even though we were going out. I quoted I Know It's Over by the Smiths: "And if you're so funny, then why are you on your own tonight?" She chuckled me right there and then. So I guess that song changed my life – or at least cleared things up.

[Rob Newman: Where the Wild Things Were](#) tours to 1 February; tour starts Norwich. His new novel, *Intelligence*, is out in early 2026.

Produced by wallabag with tcpdf

Please open [an issue](#) if you have trouble with the display of this E-Book on your device.